M365-05 · Email Alias & Address Change Standard

When the organization adds an address, when it changes one, and why those are very different operations.

Field	Value
Document ID	M365-05
Version	1.0 · Known Good edition, by Kevin Zelman
Catalogue domain	A. Microsoft 365
Operating tier	Tier 2 — Advanced Technical Services.
Review cycle	Annually.
Related existing policy	Your organization's email and account policy.

1. Purpose

This is a short standard about a small thing that causes a disproportionate amount of confusion. It says when the organization adds an email address to an existing recipient, when it changes the primary one, and why the second is a much bigger operation than it appears.

2. The distinction that causes the trouble

	Alias (adding)	Primary address (changing)
What it does	Adds another address that delivers to the same recipient.	Changes the address the recipient sends from and is known by.
Effect on delivery	Both old and new addresses work. Nothing stops working.	The old address usually keeps receiving as an alias, but everything that displays the address now shows the new one.
Effect on the recipient	None that they notice unless they want it.	Their outbound mail comes from a different address. Signatures, forms, external directories and anything hard-coded elsewhere are now wrong.
Reversible	Yes, trivially.	Technically yes; practically the confusion it causes is not reversible.
Effort	Minutes.	Minutes to do, and then a long tail of things nobody predicted.
Default answer	Yes, on a valid request.	Only for the reasons in §4.

> **The diagnostic question**
>
> When somebody asks for “a new email address”, ask: should mail to the current address keep working, and should your outbound mail keep coming from it?
>
> If yes to both — an alias. That is the overwhelming majority of requests, and it takes minutes.
>
> If they want their outbound mail to change — that is a primary address change, and §4 applies.

3. Aliases — when and how

3.1 Good reasons for an alias

- A commonly misspelled name, so that mail is not silently lost.
- A name change where the person wants to be reachable at both — which is most name changes.
- A role address that should reach the current post-holder while a shared mailbox is not warranted.
- A shorter or more memorable form of a long address, for printing on materials.
- A departmental address consolidating onto an existing mailbox or group (M365-03, M365-04).

3.2 How

1. Request through the service desk, naming the recipient and the desired alias.
2. Tier 2 confirms the alias is not already in use anywhere in the tenant — including as a group, a shared mailbox, or a former staff member’s retained address.
3. Add the alias. Do not change the primary address, and do not set the alias as the reply address unless §4 has been followed.
4. Tell the requester explicitly that outbound mail will still come from their primary address. This single sentence prevents most of the follow-up confusion.
5. Record it on the ticket.

4. Changing a primary address — when and how

A primary address is changed for two reasons and no others: a legal name change, or correction of an error made at creation.

It is not changed for a preferred name, a nickname, a marriage where the person has not changed their legal name, a department move, a promotion, or a dislike of the existing form. All of those are served by an alias, which gives the person what they actually want without the consequences.

4.1 Why the restraint

- External systems, vendor accounts, professional directories, published work and printed materials hold the old address and do not update.
- Shared mailbox and site permissions, delegations and send-as entries can be tied to it.
- Every document, ticket and email that cited the address becomes subtly wrong.
- People who remember the old form send to it, and if the alias is ever removed the mail bounces to a stranger.

4.2 How

1. Requested by the person, with HR confirmation for a legal name change.
2. Tier 2 retains the old address as an alias, permanently. Never remove it — this is the step that prevents the long tail from becoming a real problem.
3. Set the new primary address and confirm the display name and directory record match.
4. Tell the person what will now behave differently: outbound mail, signature, any external services registered under the old address, and any multifactor or password-reset contact using it.
5. Check shared mailbox membership, delegations and send-as entries still resolve.
6. Record it, including the retained alias.

5. Aliases on groups and shared mailboxes

The same mechanism and the same confusion. An alias on a group does not create a second group with different membership — it is the same set of people reachable by another address. An alias on a shared mailbox does not create a second mailbox.

This is the commonest misunderstanding in this area, and it is worth answering with the diagnostic question from §2 rather than with an explanation of the mechanism: should this reach exactly the same people, or different people?

6. What is not permitted

Not permitted	Because
Reusing an address that belonged to somebody else	Old mail, old permissions and old external references follow the string. Somebody eventually receives correspondence intended for a predecessor.
Removing a retained alias after a primary address change	Mail that was working starts bouncing, and nobody finds out until an external correspondent gives up.
An alias that impersonates a role the person does not hold	ceo@, finance@ and similar are organizational addresses, not personal ones.
An alias resembling an existing person’s address	Guarantees misdirected mail, and is a ready-made pretext for a phishing attempt (M365-22).
Using an alias to route around a mailbox owner’s approval	That is an M365-03 question, not an address question.
Encoding a department or title in a personal primary address	People move; the address then lies. ACC-02 §8 says the same thing about identifiers.

7. Service levels

Request	Commitment (per GOV-06)
Add an alias	P3 — usually same coverage day.

Request	Commitment (per GOV-06)
Primary address change, legal name change with HR confirmation	P3 — within 3 coverage days, because §4.2 steps 4 and 5 take longer than the change itself.
Primary address change for any other reason	Declined, with an alias offered instead (§4).
Alias conflicting with an existing recipient	Declined, with the conflict explained and an alternative suggested.

8. Records

Record	Held in	Retention
Alias additions	Ticket	3 years
Primary address changes, with HR confirmation and the retained alias	Ticket	Permanent — future readers need to know an address changed
Declined requests and what was offered instead	Ticket	3 years

9. Related documents

ID	Title	Relationship
Email & Account Policy	Your organization's email and account policy	The existing policy this operates under.
M365-03	Shared Mailbox Request, Provisioning & Ownership	Aliases on shared mailboxes (§5).
M365-04	Distribution List & Dynamic Group Standard	§9 of that document makes the same distinction from the group side.
M365-22	Phishing Reporting & Email Threat Response	Look-alike aliases (§6).
ACC-01	Account Lifecycle	Address assignment at creation.
ACC-02	Account Naming Standard	§3 — one person, one primary address, changed only for legal reasons.
GOV-06	Service Commitments	Supplies §7.

Appendix A — Desk card

	They ask for	You do
1	“A new email address”	Ask: should mail to your current address keep working, and should your outbound mail keep coming from it? Yes to both → alias.
2	An alias	Check it is not in use anywhere. Add it. Then tell them outbound mail still comes from the primary address.

	They ask for	You do
3	To change their address because they prefer a different form	Offer an alias. It gives them the address they want without the consequences of a change.
4	To change their address after a legal name change	HR confirmation, then §4.2. Keep the old address as an alias permanently.
5	An alias that reaches different people from the current address	That is not an alias. It is a group or a mailbox — M365-04 or M365-03.
6	An address that used to belong to somebody else	Decline. Explain that old mail and permissions follow the address.
7	ceo@ or similar for personal use	Decline. Organizational addresses are not personal.

Part of the Known Good SOP Catalog by Kevin Zelman, written for small IT shops, contractors and consultants, career-changers and help desk technicians. Adapt the names, tiers and times to your own shop: the times here are cushion, not a promise.